

Thursday, 23 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Overcast 26° 19°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 26° 16°	MANCHESTER Overcast 22° 16°	GLASGOW Overcast 20° 15°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

The widow of PC Andrew Harper has called proposals for early prisoner release 'deplorable', amid reports two of his killers could be freed early.

Lissie Harper spoke out after reports suggested some prisoners might be released early to ease overcrowding. She says the potential release of her husband's killers would be a huge blow.

CRIME · UK
- 2

The NHS trust that treated Nottingham killer Valdo Calocane before he murdered three people is now facing a manslaughter investigation.

Police have confirmed they are investigating the Nottinghamshire Healthcare NHS Foundation Trust. Calocane killed two university students and a school caretaker in the city last year.

HEALTH · UK
- 3

Some good news on the economy as food prices have fallen, but analysts are warning that inflation is expected to rise again from here.

The fall in June's inflation figures will be a relief to many. However, experts suggest this dip is only temporary and we could see prices climb again soon.

ECONOMY · UK
- 4

A new report reveals that servicewomen in the UK military are still struggling with ill-fitting kit, five years after a landmark report highlighted the issue.

Despite previous promises, women in the armed forces continue to face shortages of properly fitting uniforms and equipment. This raises concerns about their comfort and effectiveness.

DEFENCE · UK
- 5

Experts are warning of a worrying increase in young women in their 20s being diagnosed with Type 2 diabetes across England.

This trend highlights a significant health concern for a younger demographic. Health professionals are advising women to be aware of the symptoms and seek early advice.

HEALTH · UK

What's coming up

1 **A British singer had a 'chance encounter' that led to an 'alien experience' in Hollywood, landing her an unexpected role in a new blockbuster.**

Winnie Ama couldn't believe her luck when she got the opportunity to sing her original song in the upcoming Supergirl movie. However, there was a surprising catch to her big break!

ON AIR – What's the most unexpected thing that's ever happened to you?

FILM · COMING UP

2 **A massive merger between film giants Paramount and Warner Bros has been temporarily halted by a US judge.**

The proposed mega-merger, which would combine two of Hollywood's biggest studios, has been paused. This comes after 12 states launched legal action against the deal.

ON AIR – Do you think these big studio mergers are a good thing for film fans, or do they limit choice?

FILM · COMING UP

3 **The world's biggest YouTuber, MrBeast, has tied the knot with Thea Booyesen on Richard Branson's private island!**

The internet sensation, whose real name is Jimmy Donaldson, shared the happy news with his millions of fans. He joked that he had finally found his 'Mrs Beast'.

ON AIR – If you could get married anywhere in the world, where would be your dream destination?

CELEBRITY · NOW

4 **With all the buzz around new releases, many film fans are asking: 'How different is watching a movie in IMAX?'**

There's been a lot of talk online about whether films are distorted if not seen on a dedicated IMAX screen. We're looking into the viral claims to see if it makes a real difference.

ON AIR – Are you someone who always seeks out the biggest screen and best sound, or are you happy watching films at home?

FILM · NOW

5 **Is the fear of unintentionally 'going viral' changing the way young people are clubbing these days?**

For some in Gen Z, the biggest worry on a night out isn't dancing badly, but becoming accidental content for social media. It's making them think twice about how they let loose.

ON AIR – Do you ever feel self-conscious about being filmed or photographed when you're out and about?

CULTURE · NOW

On the schedule

1

World number one Luke Littler has thrown a thrilling nine-darter to book his place in the World Matchplay quarter-finals!

The teenage darts sensation continued his incredible form, beating Nathan Aspinall 11-8 in a superb performance. It was another memorable moment for the young star.

ON AIR – Luke Littler just keeps on delivering! How much further do you think he can go in this sport?

DARTS · UK

2

Manchester City midfielder Phil Foden has committed his long-term future to the club, signing a new four-year contract.

The England international will now stay with the Premier League champions until 2030. It's great news for City fans, securing one of their key homegrown talents.

ON AIR – Foden's a huge talent for club and country. How important is it for teams to hold onto their star players?

FOOTBALL · UK

3

MI London have kicked off their 2026 men's Hundred campaign with a comprehensive seven-wicket victory over Sunrisers Leeds!

Nicholas Pooran was the star, hitting a stunning 19-ball half-century. Sam Curran also played a crucial unbeaten innings of 60 to guide them home.

ON AIR – The Hundred is back! Are you excited for this year's competition, or do you prefer the traditional formats of cricket?

CRICKET · UK

4

With the 2026 Commonwealth Games kicking off in Glasgow today, we're looking at five big names to watch out for.

The Games will feature 10 sports, bringing together athletes from across the Commonwealth. Keep an eye out for these stars who are expected to shine.

ON AIR – Are you excited for the Commonwealth Games? Which sports are you most looking forward to watching?

MULTI-SPORT · UK

5

Belfast's Caoimhin Agyarko is just one fight away from making history as he challenges for the IBF light-middleweight title this Saturday.

Agyarko dreams of becoming Ireland's first black professional boxing champion. He'll face Josh Kelly in what promises to be a thrilling bout.

ON AIR – What's your favourite thing about boxing – the skill, the drama, or the incredible stories of the athletes?

BOXING · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A new study suggests that keeping houseplants can significantly improve air quality in smaller living spaces.**
Researchers found that certain leafy friends are surprisingly effective at filtering out common indoor pollutants, making your home feel a little fresher and healthier.
- 2 The delightful trend of 'positive graffiti' is quietly making its mark in communities.**
Instead of typical street art, people are leaving uplifting chalk messages and colourful drawings in public spaces, spreading smiles and good cheer.
- 3 Scientists have discovered that birds in urban areas are adapting their songs to be heard over city noise.**
This fascinating finding shows how wildlife cleverly adjusts its behaviour to thrive alongside human activity, with some birds even singing at a higher pitch.
- 4 The simple pleasure of 'writing a physical letter' is experiencing a charming resurgence among all age groups.**
Many are rediscovering the joy of putting pen to paper and sending heartfelt messages, finding it a more personal and mindful way to connect than digital communication.
- 5 A new report highlights the benefits of 'taking a scenic route' even for everyday journeys.**
The study suggests that choosing a slightly longer but prettier path can reduce stress and boost mood, turning a mundane commute into a mini-adventure.
- 6 The surprising popularity of 'board game cafes' continues to grow across the UK.**
These welcoming spots offer a chance to unplug, socialise, and enjoy a bit of friendly competition over classic and modern board games, often with a cuppa and a cake.
- 7 Research indicates that 'listening to gentle rain sounds' can significantly improve focus and relaxation.**
Many find the natural white noise of rainfall to be a perfect backdrop for concentration or unwinding, helping to mask other distracting sounds.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to put on a duvet cover?

ANSWER: HAVING A BRIEF, WRESTLING MATCH WITH IT, OFTEN INVOLVING A BIT OF LIGHT CURSING UNDER OUR BREATH!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a biscuit. What is it?

ANSWER: CAREFULLY CHECKING BOTH SIDES OF THE BISCUIT TO FIND THE 'BEST' SIDE FOR THE FIRST BITE.

TALK TOPIC

- **We all have those little 'micro-routines' that we do without even thinking, don't we?**
What's an unusual or specific little habit you have every day, perhaps just before leaving the house or starting work, that you only just realised you do?
- **Think about those 'everyday objects' that you still own, even though they're a bit past their best, simply because they hold a special memory or just 'feel right'.**
What's an old, slightly worn, but much-loved item you refuse to get rid of, and what's the story behind it?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Space.** A day on Venus is longer than a year on Venus, due to its extremely slow rotation and rapid orbit around the Sun.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** The Great Wall of China is visible from the Moon with the naked eye, making it the only man-made structure visible from space.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£59 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£59 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The world's first public park was Birkenhead Park in Merseyside, opening in 1847, and it inspired New York's Central Park.
- The inventor of the frisbee was inspired by throwing pie tins from the 'Frisbie Pie Company'.
- A group of flamingos is called a 'flamboyance'.
- It is illegal to sing out of tune in Maryland, USA, according to an old, largely unenforced law.
- Oxford University is older than the Aztec Empire.
- The colour orange was named after the fruit, not the other way around.
- A bolt of lightning is six times hotter than the surface of the sun.
- The sound of thunder is caused by the rapid expansion of air heated by a lightning bolt.

On this day

Day 204 of the year, 161 days left in 2026. Today Birthday of Haile Selassie (Rastafari); Children's Day (Indonesia); Christian feast day: Blessed Basil Hopko; Christian feast day: Bridget of Sweden. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1959 — Nancy Savoca, American director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1980 — Sandeep Parikh, American actor, director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1962 — Eriq La Salle, American actor, director, and producer
- 1961 — Woody Harrelson, American actor and activist
- 1947 — David Essex, English singer-songwriter, and actor
- 1938 — Juliet Anderson, American porn actress and producer (died 2010)
- 1973 — Kathryn Hahn, American actress
- 1944 — Dino Danelli, American drummer (died 2022)

THE DAY TODAY

- 1972 — The United States launches Landsat 1, the first Earth-resources satellite.
- 1968 — Glenville shootout: In Cleveland, Ohio, a violent shootout between a Black Militant organization and the Cleveland Police Department occurs. During the shootout, a riot begins and lasts for five days.
- 2018 — A wildfire in East Attica kills at least 102 people. It is the deadliest wildfire in the history of Greece.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 2010 — The English-Irish boy band One Direction were formed while auditioning for the 2010 series of the British singing competition The X Factor.
- 1992 — Abkhazia declares independence from Georgia.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1995 — Comet Hale-Bopp is discovered; it becomes visible to the naked eye on Earth nearly a year later.
- 1968 — The only successful hijacking of an El Al aircraft takes place when a Boeing 707 carrying ten crew and 38 passengers is taken over by three members of the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine. The aircraft was en route from Rome, to Lod, Israel.

- 1999 — Space Shuttle Columbia launches on STS-93, with Eileen Collins becoming the first female space shuttle commander. The shuttle also carried and deployed the Chandra X-ray Observatory.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 205 of the year, 160 days left in 2026. Today Carnival of Awussu (Tunisia); Children's Day (Vanuatu); Christian feast day: Charbel (Maronite Church/Catholic Church); Christian feast day: Blessed Christina the Astonishing. Star sign Leo, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1940 — Dan Hedaya, American actor
- 1936 — Ruth Buzzi, American actress and comedian (died 2025)
- 1952 — Gus Van Sant, American director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1961 — Kerry Dixon, English footballer and manager
- 1953 — Jon Faddis, American trumpet player, composer, and conductor
- 1966 — Martin Keown, English footballer and coach
- 1942 — Heinz, German-English singer-songwriter and bass player (died 2000)
- 1987 — Mara Wilson, American actress

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1974 — Watergate scandal: The United States Supreme Court unanimously ruled that President Richard Nixon did not have the authority to withhold subpoenaed White House tapes and they order him to surrender the tapes to the Watergate special prosecutor.
- 2012 — Syrian civil war: The People's Protection Units (YPG) capture the city of Girkê Legê.
- 1969 — Apollo program: Apollo 11 splashes down safely in the Pacific Ocean.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2001 — The Bandaranaike Airport attack is carried out by 14 Tamil Tiger commandos, resulting in military and civilian casualties and destroyed aircraft.
- 2013 — Santiago de Compostela derailment: A high-speed train derails in Spain rounding a curve with an 80 km/h (50 mph) speed limit at 190 km/h (120 mph), killing 78 passengers.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026	
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)